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Of Wifely Woes and the Emperor's Death

ACROSS THE PRECEDING PAGES THE HISTORICAL ASHOKA has emerged over nearly two decades of his reign in many avataras: the remorseful conqueror of Kalinga, the proactive propagandist of non-violence, the imperious king threatening violence against forest people, the pious Buddhist pilgrim at Lumbini, the supportive spouse implementing his consort's wishes. A variety of people in the India of his time have also appeared: officials, scribes, travellers, neighbouring monarchs, Hindu and Jaina vegetarians, Afghan meat-eaters, monks and nuns.

With the pillar edicts done, Ashoka's compelling voice falls silent all at once. No more messages appear on rocks and pillars addressed to administrators and the populace. The metaphors that he had used, the idiom and language of his edicts, the examples and intent to forge connections between his own life and that of his subjects—they all finish. The silence, because of its suddenness, is deafening.

Why? It is not as if Ashoka suddenly passed away. In fact if the literary chronicles in which the last years of his rulership and death figure are to be believed, he continued to rule for about a decade after promulgating the Seventh Pillar Edict till around 232 BCE. But he ceased to speak through public messages on stone. It is possible that new inscriptions will be discovered bearing regnal dates of that last decade, but as things stand our knowledge of Ashoka's dotage comes from the same old chronicles that were composed centuries after his reign and which were written often with the intention of deifying him. The story of Ashoka's life, then, is back where it began, embedded in unverifiable tradition. The historical issue